Simultaneously, however, Honecker laboured under the hope that new trade links with the United States, especially in agricultural products, would keep the economy moving. He was also heartened by a fisheries agreement opening American ports to GDR ships, and a visit from the British Trade Secretary Edmund Dell seeking new opportunities marked the first trip to East Berlin by a British Cabinet Minister since the Second World War. On top of that, 'Intershop', the burgeoning chain of hard-currency stores, recorded 9.5 million visitors annually, bringing dollars, Sterling and Deutsche Marks. Also, vast foreign reserves continued to arrive via Genex, East Germany's official trading company in the West, an outfit aimed at securing Western currency by selling products ranging from self-assembly kitchens to textiles at prices set to undercut the Western market. In competing on the global market with the low-wage countries from the Third World and with China, the GDR dumped its merchandise at cheap rates while people at home paid dearly. For example, as exports always had the foremost priority, the high-quality East German Wernesgrüner beer could be found on sale in West Berlin supermarkets but not in the Eastern part of the city; likewise, fine woodwork from the Ore Mountains was unavailable in nearby Dresden but obtainable in Hamburg. With quality goods earmarked for export, what remained in the country was often only junk or of second-rate quality. For instance, one particular model of a cassette recorder priced DDM650 was of such miserable quality that it conked out after just a few minutes of operation. Jokers with testy complaints had already concocted a gag: 'Erich Honecker, during an inspection tour of a factory, asks about the rejects in the ratio to production. The answer: 8 per cent. The SED boss: "Is this enough to supply the people in the GDR?"'

A murkier source of income was secured by the thriving trade in political prisoners. Between 1963 and 1989, the FRG made ransom payments to free over 30,000 political prisoners from East Germany in exchange for around DM3 billion. Additionally, Wolfgang Vogel, a Honecker confidant, negotiated much-desired exit visas to the West for many East German families and was later said to have blackmailed several GDR citizens in the process. But Vogel had other motivations, too. It emerged in 1993 that over 200 people seeking to leave the GDR were forced to give their land to officials, Stasi officers and other SED beneficiaries, via Vogel's mediation. In sixteen specific cases, Vogel was accused of coercing people wishing to